Are they working on the right stuff?

What the NSS Board of Governors put on its agendas in 2026, set beside what you think should be on them

BOG Watch · Aaron Bird, NSS #27029 (FE) · Thursday 22 October 2026

How tonight works

1 · The record

What the Board moved, voted and reported in open session, January to the 17 October agenda. Every item has a source. This part is fact.

2 · The room

What you think should be on the Board's list, and what you think it has done well this year. This part is opinion, and it is yours, not BOG Watch's.

3 · What happens next

Tonight's list becomes the draft issue list for a short questionnaire to cavers across North America: what should NSS governance be working on? Results will be published with the method.

Same three ground rules. Public records only, retrieved with no login. Not affiliated with the NSS. Facts, sources and questions, not findings. One limit tonight: the record shows what reached an agenda or a vote, not what committees, staff or closed sessions worked on.

Minutes of 14 September are still a draft; 17 October is agenda only, no minutes yet.

What the Board put on its agendas in 2026

Meeting	Open-session business	Reported from closed session
5 Jan	$30,000 from the Litigation to Protect Caves fund for Mill Creek Sink legal costs	Closed session, 65 min
14 Mar	FY2026-27 budget ($1.52M) · up to $60,000 to demolish Cave Avenue · $190,000 Beech Fund note for the museum	Closed session, 2 h 18 min
13 Apr	March minutes postponed	Kok appointed Director · employee review process discussed
28 Apr	MOUs with US Forest Service and Appalachian Cave Conservancy · Thunderhole JMA	Closed session, 63 min
27 May	Museum Board members: postponed	—
29 Jun	Museum Board slate: denied · $190,000 museum note rescinded	Executive Director's contract terminated without cause
6 Jul	NCRC and VTC financial policies · $100,000 each to NCRC and VTC · NSF fund contracts · Board HR support budget · ~48 motions rewriting the fiscal Acts (ED → Secretary-Treasurer)	Reports: audit update, Ramp, strategic planning resuming
14 Sep	$55,000 for the Executive Director search · Code of Conduct report accepted	Investment Review Department created · one member's questions on meeting notice and the ED job description
17 Oct	Conflict of Interest Policy · add Secretary-Treasurer and Executive Staff to Act 03-445 · unfinished business: none	NCRC legal update · legal expense approvals (added the night before)

Sources: final minutes posted 15 Oct 2026 (5 Jan–6 Jul), draft minutes of 14 Sep, agenda of 17 Oct (both uploads). Full list with citations: BOG_Watch/2026-10-22.

The same record, by theme

$535k

committed by motion: Mill Creek $30k · Cave Avenue $60k · museum $190k (rescinded) · NCRC $100k · VTC $100k · ED search $55k

~48

motions in July rewriting the fiscal Acts; plus NSF fund contracts, Ramp, a new Investment Review Department. Who controls the accounts.

4

land and partner agreements: USFS MOU, Appalachian Cave Conservancy MOU, Thunderhole JMA, Mill Creek litigation.

7

people items: ED terminated · a Director appointed · Museum Board slate denied · Code of Conduct · HR support · ED search · COI policy.

Not on any 2026 open-session agenda: Article III of the Constitution · the missing FY2022 Form 990 · publishing an audit (last one: FY2008-09) · an evaluation framework for the Executive Director · membership numbers · communication with members, beyond one member's question on 14 September.

Counts are of open-session motions and reports in the posted minutes and the 17 Oct agenda. Closed-session work is not visible.

Since the last call: the 17 October meeting

The Conflict of Interest Policy

Posted on caves.org the day before the vote. Every page is footered “06052026”, a 5 June document; the file name says “Updated 10_16_2026”.

The Certificate of Adoption is pre-filled “approved and adopted … on October 17, 2026”, for signature by the Chair and the Secretary-Treasurer.

It is the IRS model policy, adapted “to answer questions on Form 990”. The last three returns answered No to having one.

A conflict exists “only if the Chair of the Board and/or the Executive Director decides”. The Interim Executive Director is the Secretary-Treasurer.

The agenda, and what it did not contain

Two motions: adopt the policy, and add “the Secretary-Treasurer, all Executive Staff” to Act 03-445, which the agenda calls a Bylaw.

Unfinished business: none.

A second copy was uploaded the night before the meeting. The only change: a new closed-session item, “7.2 Legal expense approvals”. Both copies say V 1.0.

Draft minutes are not yet posted. What was said under item 4, Comments from the Membership, is not yet on the record.

Sources: Conflict-of-Interest-Policy…Updated-10_16_2026.docx.pdf and 1017-BoG-Agenda.pdf / -1.pdf on caves.org, fetched 22 Oct 2026, SHA-256 on file.

Now the room

1 What should be on the Board's list that isn't?

2 What has the Board done well this year?

3 Of everything named tonight, which three matter most to you?

Your answers are recorded as attendees' views, not as BOG Watch findings. They become the draft issue list for the questionnaire to cavers across North America, to be released after this call.